

English

Stage 9

Paper 1 Non-fiction

2022

Cambridge Lower Secondary Progression Test

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Text A

Subterranean ghost stations

In 1920, construction began on an important new transport system for Cincinnati, in the USA. Voters had given support to this \$6m local venture, and despite concerns about the economy, the project began. Little did the city officials know that the system they were building would never carry a single passenger. Five years later, the money had run out, the government refused to help and construction was halted. Today, there is an entire 10km subway system abandoned underneath the Cincinnati streets.

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Though Cincinnati is an extreme case of an empty subway network, it's part of a pattern of abandoning stations globally. Underground travel has become a familiar routine for millions of city dwellers throughout the world. However, most commuters are unaware that lurking on the other side of the walls are the remains of deserted stations, slowly deteriorating. No longer part of the daily lives of people, nevertheless these stations are a link to their cities' past. Known as 'ghost stations', they are silent but powerful reminders of forgotten history.

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Tom Moran, an expert on abandoned stations, says: 'They were built to cater for large crowds of people – unlike sewers and utility tunnels – and thus contain all the features of a public space, from fire escapes to ornate signage and advertising on the walls. It's that missing human element that makes them more eerie.'

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Subways are important ways for citizens to get around, but they're also important as public spaces. Indeed, by providing a shared experience, subway systems are often important parts of the distinctive identities of cities like Paris, London and New York. If you rob the stations of their healthy blood flow of regular commuters, the stations will eventually haunt the city.

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Many ghost stations are being used for temporary purposes. In Toronto, Canada, a station has become a location for parties during the film festival while in New York a station was transformed into a short-term exhibition space for Brooklyn street artists.

However, neglected stations are crying out to be used, not just as pop-up hangouts, but as permanent features of city life. Maybe that's why a recent proposal to repurpose deserted stations in Paris as public pools and auditoriums has gained support.

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Are these stations better left to urban explorers? Tom Moran explains, 'Other than filling them in, you can't really demolish an underground ghost station ... the fact that they generally don't go through the normal periodic upgrades makes them like time capsules.'

And the best way to ruin a time capsule is to open it.

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Text B

Round the world in 80 trains

Ever wanted to run and take the Trans-Siberian Railway from Moscow to Beijing? Wind through the Canadian Rockies or cut straight through the heart of Australia – all to the click-clack of train tracks? Well, the Man in Seat Sixty-One has the website for you!

Although the name of his website might make him sound mysterious, Mark Smith is in fact the man behind the massively popular website, Seat61.com. It offers invaluable advice on worldwide train travel. Now Mark has written a book, which is the essential guide for anyone who wishes to travel the world by train. It is packed with insider knowledge and top tips on everything from the quickest routes and the cheapest fares to the best weekends away; travelling with children and changing trains; timetables and maps; essential items to travel with; and everything in between.

We need to reduce our carbon footprint, and short-haul flights are stressful, frustrating and often irresponsible. Therefore, the importance of embracing affordable, efficient and comfortable rail travel cannot be overemphasised. Through his website and book, Mark Smith says he wants to inspire people to do something more exciting with their lives and their travel opportunities than going to an airport, getting on a plane and missing all the world has to offer. 'There's more to travel than the destination. It used to be called a journey.'

If you're looking for a travel experience that doesn't involve flying, want to book a once-in-a-lifetime trip round the world, or you simply want to seek out a travel adventure via train – this is the ultimate website.

All aboard!

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